RESEARCH SOURCEBOOK · SVT NYHETER HELSINGBORG INTERVIEW PREPARATION · OCTOBER 2026

Food and AI: A Sourcebook on AI-Generated Menu Imagery

Complete text, transcripts, and described images from six linked sources: The Guardian, CNN, Instagram (Jenny Frennberg), Reddit r/sweden, The New York Times, and TikTok.

Compiled from the Food / AI Sourcebook web archive (`web/food-ai`). Built 2026-10-26.

About this book

This book gathers every piece of content in the Food + AI web archive into one document that can be searched and used for retrieval-augmented (RAG) question answering. The archive was built from the six topical links in *svt.pdf*, a three-page Swedish email thread setting up an SVT Nyheter Helsingborg interview about AI-generated food images in restaurant menus and advertising.

Conventions for retrieval. Each chapter covers one source and opens with a source card giving its title, URL, kind and archive status. Article text is reproduced in full, as extracted. Social media text is reproduced verbatim in its original language (mostly Swedish) and labelled by author and timestamp. Images and video frames are embedded, and each comes with a written *visual description* so that its content can be searched as text. Text marked “written for this book” (visual descriptions, translations, summaries) is editorial material added during compilation and is not part of the original sources.

Gaps. The New York Times interactive and the TikTok discovery feed could not be retrieved. Chapter 6 records these gaps; nothing has been invented to fill them.

Contents

This content is also available as separate files, one per source. Chapter numbers mentioned in the text refer to the full book, `food-ai-sourcebook.pdf`:

- `food-ai-intro.pdf`: Introduction, overview, source catalogue and glossary
- `food-ai-guardian.pdf`: The Guardian article (book chapter 2)
- `food-ai-cnn.pdf`: CNN article (book chapter 3)
- `food-ai-instagram.pdf`: Instagram reel by Jenny Frennberg (book chapter 4)
- `food-ai-reddit.pdf`: Reddit r/sweden discussion (book chapter 5)
- `food-ai-nytimes.pdf`: The New York Times interactive, retrieval note (book chapter 6.1)
- `food-ai-tiktok.pdf`: TikTok discovery page, retrieval note (book chapter 6.2)

Chapter 1. Overview: the question, the sources, and the main explanations

1.1 The interview request (svt.pdf)

The source PDF is a three-page Swedish email thread preparing an SVT Nyheter Helsingborg interview about AI-generated food images in restaurant menus and advertising. It describes generative imagery moving off the internet and into everyday physical communication: menus, food trucks, signs and restaurant advertising. It raises five questions:

- Why are businesses adopting AI-generated food imagery?
- Why are reactions unusually strong when the subject is food?
- Why do the images have a recognisable visual character?
- Is the "uncanny valley" a useful explanation?
- Will audiences get used to it as synthetic imagery becomes more common?

1.2 The six linked sources

Source	Type	What it contributes	Status
The Guardian (6 Sep 2026)	News article	US reporting on restaurants adopting AI menu images to cut costs; diner backlash (Denver, San Francisco); DoorDash "AI-enhanced" tool; Charles Spence's research.	Complete, chapter 2
CNN (2 Sep 2026)	News article	Global examples (Los Angeles, New York, Tokyo, Kuala Lumpur, Berlin); uncanny valley; Alexander Diel's psychology research on disgust and food neophobia; restaurant economics (National Restaurant Association figures); advice from the International Association of Culinary Professionals.	Complete, chapter 3
Instagram reel by Jenny Frennberg	Social video (48 s)	A Stockholm food creator's appeal to Swedish restaurateurs to skip AI menu images.	Complete, chapter 4
Reddit r/sweden thread (Oct 2026)	Social discussion	Swedish audience reactions (original post and 198 comments) to an AI-generated, Pokémon-themed hot-dog menu at ICA Maxi in Skellefteå.	Complete, chapter 5
The New York Times (6 Oct 2026)	News interactive	"Why A.I. Food Slop Looks So Gross"	Blocked, chapter 6
TikTok discovery page	Social discovery feed	Search phrase "ai food looks disgusting"	Feed not available, chapter 6

1.3 Recurring explanations across the sources (synthesis)

The retrievable sources point to five overlapping explanations:

1. **Economics.** Generated images are cheap and quick to make. Restaurant margins are thin: 42% of US operators did not turn a profit in 2025, and 26% use AI, mostly for marketing (National Restaurant Association). Owners quoted in the sources used ChatGPT instead of paying a designer or photographer.
2. **Visual defects.** Texture, lighting and structure come out wrong: leathery or rubbery meat, bread that looks like reptile skin or a loofah, pasta like yarn or Play-Doh, ring-shaped “shrimp”, repeated forms, excess gloss and saturation, and layouts that are too geometric.
3. **Uncanny valley.** Masahiro Mori’s 1970 concept describes the eerie feeling caused by near-human figures with slight flaws. Diel’s research found that slightly imperfect AI food images are rated more uncanny and less pleasant than either clearly unrealistic or highly realistic ones.
4. **Food-specific disgust.** Food can make us ill, so people are sensitive to anything that looks “slightly off”. Two candidate mechanisms are evolved disgust, which guards against contamination, and food neophobia, a wariness of unfamiliar food. Viewers want to eat AI food less even when they judge it equally healthy.
5. **Trust and truth in advertising.** A photograph can be styled, but it still implies that the dish existed. A generated image may show food that never did. Diners call this false advertising, read it as a sign of cut corners (“if they skimp on the signage they skimp on the food”), worry about hallucinated allergen labels, and in Sweden point to Japan’s strict rules on food imagery as a model. Charles Spence found that people preferred AI food images until they were told the images were AI-made.

“Uncanny valley” works as shorthand for imagery that is almost real but perceptually wrong. Food-specific disgust and expectations about truthful advertising add mechanisms that go beyond the term’s original context of humans and robots. On habituation, the evidence is mixed. In 2023 more than 60% of people in a Slerp survey could not tell AI food images from photos, but the 2025–2026 reporting describes growing sensitivity and backlash. Restaurants have also begun advertising “no AI” as a selling point (Chugwater Soda Fountain, Wyoming).

Appendix A: Catalogue of sources and files

Directory	Original URL	Archived files
guardian	https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2026/sep/06/ai-food-menu-images	guardian/content.txt guardian/images/image-01.jpg guardian/images/image-02.jpg guardian/images/image-03.jpg guardian/metadata.json guardian/source.html
cnn	https://edition.cnn.com/2026/09/02/us/ai-food-slop-menus-viral-cec	cnn/content.txt cnn/images/image-01.jpg cnn/images/image-02.jpg cnn/images/image-03.jpg cnn/metadata.json cnn/source.html
instagram	https://www.instagram.com/reel/DeUPt1mIz5n/	instagram/Video_by_jennyfrennberg-DeUPt1mIz5n.info.json instagram/Video_by_jennyfrennberg-DeUPt1mIz5n.jpg instagram/Video_by_jennyfrennberg-DeUPt1mIz5n.mp4 instagram/content.txt instagram/metadata.json instagram/source.html instagram/subtitles-de.vtt instagram/subtitles-en.vtt instagram/transcript-de.txt instagram/transcript-en.txt
reddit	https://www.reddit.com/r/sweden/comments/1wwl6wv/vad_tycker_ni_om_att_allt_fler_restauranger_har/	reddit/blocked-json-response.html reddit/content.txt reddit/images/image-01.jpg reddit/metadata.json reddit/old-reddit.html reddit/source.html reddit/thread.atom
nytimes	https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2026/10/06/technology/ai-slop-food-images-restaurant-menus.html	nytimes/content.txt nytimes/metadata.json nytimes/source.html
tiktok	https://www.tiktok.com/discover/ai-food-looks-disgusting	tiktok/content.txt tiktok/metadata.json tiktok/source.html

Each directory holds `metadata.json` and `content.txt`. `source.html` is the unmodified direct response. `MANIFEST.sha256` in the archive root records checksums.

A.1 Image catalogue

Figure	File	Shows

2-1	guardian/images/image-01.jpg	Bella Cafe (San Francisco) western-themed breakfast menu poster, made with ChatGPT
2-2	guardian/images/image-02.jpg	Jamaican BBQ pop-up (Denver) combo menu, meat looking like leather belts with beetles
2-3	guardian/images/image-03.jpg	DoorDash “AI-enhanced” Chicken Katsu listing
3-1	cnn/images/image-01.jpg	New York deli hot-entrees board with ring-shaped “shrimp scampi” (photo: Sam Biddle)
3-2	cnn/images/image-02.jpg	Freedom 250 AI portraits of founding fathers (related CNN story, not food)
3-3	cnn/images/image-03.jpg	Freesh Juice Bar AI-style smoothie advertisement (CNN lead image)
4-1	instagram/…mp4 (frames)	Eight frames from Jenny Frennberg’s reel, including the “MALATANG – Nu på buffén!” poster
4-2	instagram/…jpg	Reel thumbnail: Jenny Frennberg on a Stockholm street
5-1	reddit/images/image-01.jpg	ICA Maxi Stormarknad (Skellefteå) AI-generated Pokémon-themed hot-dog menu screen

Appendix B: Glossary of key concepts, people and organisations

AI slop / AI slop menus
Pejorative term for low-effort generative AI content. TikTok users apply it to restaurant menus with AI images (CNN).

Uncanny valley
Concept introduced by Japanese roboticist Masahiro Mori in 1970: eerie or repellent feelings caused by near-human figures with slight imperfections. Applied to near-realistic AI food images (CNN, Guardian).

Food neophobia
Fear of or reluctance to try unfamiliar foods; one hypothesis for aversion to AI food images (Diel, CNN).

Disgust (evolutionary)
An emotion that protects against harmful or contaminated food. Slightly-off food images may trigger it (Diel, CNN).

Alexander Diel
Psychologist at the University of Duisburg-Essen, Germany, who studies responses to AI food images. A 2025 peer-reviewed study found slightly imperfect AI food rated more uncanny and less pleasant; a 2026 study found lower desire to eat AI food despite equal health and calorie judgements.

Charles Spence
Oxford professor of experimental psychology. His 2024 study found that consumers preferred AI food images until told they were AI-made. AI tends to add fat (e.g. butter) when asked to make food look appealing, which might nudge people toward bigger, fattier portions (Guardian).

National Restaurant Association (NRA)
Its 2026 report says 26% of US restaurant operators use AI, mostly for marketing, and that 42% did not turn a profit in 2025.

Slerp
British restaurant ordering platform. Its 2023 survey of 100 people found more than 60% could not tell AI food images from photos (founder JP Then).

Nancy Hopkins
President of the International Association of Culinary Professionals. She advises using AI for scheduling and payroll, not food pictures, and using smartphone photos or illustrations instead: “Real people, real stories will always be better.”

Hunter Lewis
Editor in chief of Food & Wine. He says AI use should be invisible to diners: “The American dining public is smart.”

Kat Kinsman
Food & Wine features editor who wrote about the “uncanny valley of a dish I know cannot be real”.

Jamie Soja
Bay Area food photographer. AI gets texture, colour, arrangement and lighting wrong (Guardian).

Jill Sennett
Denver nurse who posted the Jamaican BBQ pop-up menu on X.

Grind & Unwind
San Francisco café whose AI signage drew graffiti (“seriously”); owner Lyndsey Lozano spent about $700 removing it.

Bella Cafe
San Francisco café using ChatGPT-made menu signs; owner Nila Norero Salvatore likes them. Brandon Hill posted about it on X.

Chugwater Soda Fountain
Wyoming restaurant whose hand-written “no AI” pledge got more than 200,000 Instagram likes.

DoorDash “AI-enhanced”
Label applied automatically when restaurants use DoorDash’s AI photo tool to adjust lighting, colour or background. Misleading images are prohibited by policy.

Adaeze Onejeme, Julia Damphouse, Sam Biddle
People in the CNN article who documented AI menus in Los Angeles (“AI flyer epidemic”), Berlin, and a New York deli (“shrimp scampi”) respectively.

Jenny Frennberg
Stockholm food creator (“Stockholm Food Gems”) whose reel urges Swedish restaurateurs to skip AI menu images.

ICA Maxi Stormarknad, Skellefteå
Swedish supermarket whose AI-generated, Pokémon-themed street-food menu set off the r/sweden thread.